

which we should measure our lives? I'm still searching for the ultimate answer to that question. But I know that we can never let things as such—the material possessions we may come to accumulate—become the measure of our lives. In a nation as rich with material abundance as ours, a cornucopia of things almost beyond measure, it is an easy trap to fall into. Two and a half thousand years ago, the Greek philosopher Protagoras told us that “man is the measure of all things.” Today, I fear, we are becoming a society in which “things are the measure of the man.”

Indeed, there's a perhaps tongue-in-cheek aphorism that whoever dies with the most toys wins. Such a measure is absurd; it is superficial; and, finally, it is self-defeating. The world has far too many calls on its limited resources to expend them on things trivial and things transitory. There are literally billions of human beings out there, all over the globe, who cry out for support and for salvation, for security and for compassion, for education and for opportunity—those intangibles that carry a value far in excess of so many tangible things whose nature is, finally, inconsequential. One of my favorite hymns, “God of Grace and God of Glory,” says it better than I can: “Cure Thy children's warring madness, bend our pride to Thy control; Shame our wanton, selfish gladness, rich in things and poor in soul.”

If it is surprising that a Hollywood film would be concerned with the things by which one measures one's life, it might be even more surprising that a businessman— particularly one in the investment arena, where greed seems the order of the day—would echo that concern. But I have had cause enough to know that the road of life is rarely smooth and that we need to be prepared for the inevitable reversals in our fortunes, whether constituted by wealth, or health, or family.

Now at 79 years of age, I've also lived long enough to recognize the wisdom of that pointed warning from Ecclesiastes: “The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong,<sup>20</sup> neither yet bread to the wise, nor yet riches to men of understanding, nor yet favor to men of skill, but time and chance happeneth to them all.” Put another way, time and chance can bestow things on you, and take them